

VICTOR FRANKEL

ORIGIN:

Victor Frankl's way of looking at life, called existential perspective, comes from his tough experiences in the Holocaust and his interest in philosophy and psychology. He noticed how people stayed strong by finding meaning even in really hard times. His ideas, like everyone having a unique purpose and the importance of finding meaning, make up his way of thinking called logo therapy.

His perspective

He emphasizes that the search for meaning is a fundamental human drive. He argues that even in the face of suffering, individuals have the freedom to choose their attitude and find purpose.

Early Life and Hardship:

Victor Frankl faced tough times during World War II in concentration camps, where he observed how finding meaning helped people stay strong despite extreme challenges.

Development of Logo therapy:

After the war, Frankl turned his observations into a therapy method called logo therapy, centred on helping individuals discover their purpose in life.

Influences and Philosophy:

Inspired by existential philosophy and thinkers like Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, and Heidegger, Frankl integrated these ideas into his approach, emphasizing personal uniqueness and the search for meaning.

Publication of "Man's Search for Meaning":

Frankl shared his experiences and thoughts in the book "Man's Search for Meaning," becoming a cornerstone in psychology and highlighting the importance of finding purpose in life.

Legacy and Continued Influence:

Frankl's existential perspective continues to impact psychology, showing that discovering meaning can be a powerful tool for coping with life's difficulties. His ideas remain influential in understanding happiness and fulfilment.

Logo Therapy

Victor Frankl developed logo therapy in 1940s. His suffering and experiences in the **Nazi concentration camps** inspired him to develop logotherapy. “Logo” comes from Greek word “logos” means “meaning”. “Therapy” refers to treating an illness or maladjustment.

Logotherapy is a school of psychotherapy which is based on the belief that human beings are motivated by the search for meaning in life.

Logotherapy, founded by Viktor Frankl, maintains that discovery of meaning in life can help people overcome difficulties of any intensity.



Principles of Logotherapy

- Freedom of Will
- Will to Meaning
- Meaning in Life

Logotherapy Techniques

- Dereflection
- Socratic Dialogue
- Paradoxical Intention

How Does One Find Meaning?

- Create or accomplish something
- Experience something or love someone fully
- Have an adaptive attitude toward inescapable adversity

Based on premise that:

Primary motivational force of an individual is to find meaning in life (postulates meaning in life). It emphasizes personal responsibility and promotes the idea that meaning of life is found through love, work and attitude toward suffering.

Causes of problem:

- Hyper reflection
- Hyper attention

Hyper reflection:

Excessive self monitoring and worry about one's performance and self image .

Hyper intention:

Intentionally trying to force or avoid an outcome.

Core Components of Logotherapy

Viktor Frankl highlighted three core components, around which the theory and therapy was built. The three components were as follows:

1. Every individual has a healthy core.
2. The primary aim is to help people understand and recognize their internal resources and use them.
3. Life provides people with purpose, but it does not guarantee a feeling of fulfilment or happiness.

Principles of Logotherapy

There are three principles of this therapy.

1. The freedom of will
2. The will to meaning
3. The meaning of life

1. The freedom of will

Logotherapy is based on the principle that people have the freedom and ability to shape their psychological (internal), physiological and social (external) environments. The freedom of will encompasses the spiritual dimension of human beings. That is, it is above and beyond the physical and psychological realms. This concept enables people to foster a sense of autonomy and control even during times of distress.

2. Will to Meaning

Apart from having freedom, people are free to achieve their purpose. When people cannot seek and create such meaning, they are filled with a sense of emptiness, which leads to psychological disorders.

Logotherapy helps people to recognize and eliminate factors that come in the way of their pursuit of meaning. It allows people to perceive opportunities to create meaning but does not offer a specific purpose altogether. It guides and does not offer a solution as in the case of most schools of psychotherapy. Due to Frankl's belief that the primary basic need is for meaning in life, he rejects Maslow's theory. Maslow's distinction between higher and lower needs does not take into account that when lower needs are not satisfied, a higher need, such as the will to meaning, may become more urgent.

A will to pleasure or need-satisfaction is not the primary tendency of human nature. Happiness is experienced as a by-product of completing a task or having experienced something of value. The more meaning we attain in our lives, the more we will be actualised –just as happiness is the by-product of the discovery of meaning. The more meaning we attain in our lives, the more we will be actualised –just as happiness is the by-product of the discovery of meaning.

3. Meaning in Life

According to logotherapy, meaning is not just an illusion that gets invoked in an individual. Instead, it is an objective truth. Therefore, logotherapy allows individuals to be their best and make the best of each situation by recognizing and realising its meaning. Here, meaning potentials are dynamic despite being objective as each situation is different from the other.

Meaning in life can be found in three principle ways: the creative things we do, the uplifting things we experience, and the kind of attitude we have towards situations of unavoidable sufferings. When we are no longer able to change a situation, we are challenged to change ourselves. By changing ourselves, by rising above & growing beyond ourselves, we exercise the most creative of all human potentials. Everything can be taken from man but one thing: the last of the human freedoms –to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way. Suffering has meaning –it offers us the opportunity to transcend adversity. The freedom to live a life of worth and dignity remains, even in suffering.

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Techniques of logo therapy

Following are three techniques of logo therapy:

1. Dereflection
2. Socratic Dialogue
3. Paradoxical intention

1. Dereflection

Dereflection counters self observation by 'ignoring' one's symptoms. Key word (attention) Focuses on act of redirecting one's attention. Encourage individuals who're obsessed with problem to shift their attention from their problems and their worry to something of larger importance. By doing so they can find deeper sense of meaning and purpose. Dereflection emphasize about important of recognizing that your 'meaning in life consists of what you're presently engaged in and passionate about'. It's not about ignoring your problems but shifting your **attention** to what truly matters.

For instance: Frankel recounted case where a young man had speech disturbance due to traumatic childhood experience. He was consistently pre-occupied with speaking correctly, fearing he would never be public speaker. This self obsession hindered his performance.

Dereflection helped him to shift his focus from self concern to self commitment. He began paying **attention** to his content of speech rather than how he was delivering it. This change allowed him to reconnect with his mission in life and replace self concern with self commitment.

2. Socratic Dialogue

Socratic dialogue is a conversational technique that allows people to identify counterproductive beliefs and generate a fresh and healthier attitude to lead a more fulfilling life.

Simply put, Socratic dialogue is used to help people discover answers that they already possess but of which they are not yet aware. The therapist actively listens to the patient's descriptions of their problems. They then help the patient recognize patterns in their speech and understand their meaning.

3. Paradoxical intention

According to Frankel:

The patient is encouraged to do or go wish to happen the very things he fears (the former applying to phobic patients, the latter to obsessive compulsive). The technique builds on human capacity for self detachment to break vicious cycle, which traps people in psychogenic neuroses, such as phobia, anxiety, and obsessive compulsive behavior. Self attachment enables patient to adapt a new attribute to stand back or laugh at situation or self.

Fear is removed when action/intention focuses on what is feared the most. For example, if a person struggles with a fear of rejection, they would purposely put themselves in positions where they would be rejected or told "no."

In applying **paradoxical intention** the therapist tries to "mobilize and utilize exclusive human capacity for humor".

Applying this technique on Phobic Patients:

For phobic patient, he has a "fearful expectation" that a particular symptom occur and his fears create "anxiety" which in turns brings about what patient fears to happen.

This "**fear of fear**" creates "**vicious cycle**"

The most common reaction to "fear of fear" is "flight from fear" and phobic pattern is maintained by excessive avoidance. This vicious cycle is broken when "pathogenic fear is replaced by paradoxical wish" As a result the patient no longer avoids the situation that create anxiety.

With **phobic patients** paradoxical intention begins with self detachment.

The second step is to ask patient to develop new attitude of not fearing but welcoming symptoms. This typically results in reduction of symptoms which allow therapists to work toward enhancing meaningful living.

Another example of this technique can come from someone with a fear of public speaking. This fear usually stems from a fear of saying or doing something embarrassing. In such a case, the therapist will encourage the client to behave as silly as possible.

Doing this can allow the client to realise they are not doing anything embarrassing like they had imagined. Alternatively, with the help of the therapist, the client can learn how to respond if someone laughs at them.

In case of **obsessive compulsive disorder** the patient fights against obsession or compulsions. The more he fights against those symptoms, the stronger they become. Again a vicious cycle is created the patient with compulsive hand washing because of fear of infection would be told to let himself "I can't get enough bacteria, I want to become as dirty as possible"

